HEROES OF NORMANDIE

The Devil Pig News

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OUISTREHAM

PLACE YOUR BETS!

GREEN CARPET

'The commandos wish everyone a warm hello. The commander of the Green Berets greets his friends and wants to tell them that Hitler is already wetting his pants. Have courage. We are going to win. Vive La France!
Lord Lovat.

On June 6th 1944, only 177 French Fusiliers Marine Commando bear the Free France colors for the first day of recapture which started on the beaches of Normandy. Sword Beach, Queen red sector, Kieffer's men landed at 7:30 am in the middle of hell. Indeed, even if the heavy shelling from the navy and the air force was quite efficient, the Germans of the 716ID answered with fierce resistance.

"…At this precise moment, the ground and the sea seem to rise with a rumble of thunder: mortar shells exploding, piercing whistle of shells flying overhead, abrasive knocking of the machine-guns, everything seems concentrated on us. In a flash, the doors hit the ground. Bearing the green beret, a first group rush to the beach, but a few seconds before the rush of the second group, a 75mm shell blows off the doors of the landing craft and pieces of wood and metal fly in all directions." (P. Kiefer, Berêt vert)

The losses are heavy and they have to fight in close combats to assure control of the beach (to the Hollywood legend which pretends that beside the US sector, the D-Day landing was just a formality). Thirty French were already hors de combat.

Once the beach is "secured", orders are as follows: seize the Riva-Bella gun battery then, connect with the paratroopers who hold the Pegasus Bridge. But before that, direction Ouistreham. The town is held by a battalion of 736 Grenadier Regiment of the 716ID. We find a HQ, observation positions, a battery command center and several support points including the Wn 10 where the old Riva-Bella Casino used to stand. Note that this position was holding four 155mm French cannons (irony of history) and some 75mm pieces. The 155mm cannons were moved a little farther after the bombing of 1944, but still… four 75mm shells! It's still something, especially when you receive them in your face. The French start the assault, but the Krauts resist, and Kieffer is wounded (he will be wounded twice in one day on June 6th 1944). The casino is protected by two 20mm cannons which are devastating for the attackers, and Kiefer himself must conduct a Centaure from the 13th/18th Royal Hussars to finally take over the casino and finish the job with grenades and knives.

The casino neutralized, the French and British of the 2nd Battalion East Yorkshire Regiment backed by tanks from the 13th/18th Royal Hussars take over the support point Wn12 (the same one where the 155mm cannons where located) and then they hold solid control of the town despite some isolated snipers. When it is time to go to the Bénouville bridge where they arrive without incident to connect with Major Howard's men, and before going back towards Amfreville to entrench themselves, the French commandos already lost 7 men including the sub-lieutenant Hubert and the captain doctor Lion, plus sixty wounded which is no small matter considering the starting size of the commando. Of 177 men, only 24 will go through the 83 days of the Normandy campaign without even a boil on their ass. Most of them had not laid a foot in France for the past 4 years.

Laurent

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COMMANDER PHILIPPE KIEFFER

It's funny how we find more sailers in Britany than in Alsace, except when they are born in Haïti, like little Philippe Kieffer on October 24th 1899. Port-au-Prince being closer to the sea than Molsheim-les-Flammekueche may explain it. Even though, young Philippe resisted the call of the sea for a long time while wasting his time at business school to become a banker. Fortunately, the war and its cortege of virile happiness took him away from his depressing fate. He returned to France in 1939 and volunteered (at 40 years old!) first to serve in the army (really! What an idea!) then finally in the "Royale" (the navy). Kiefer has been in every battle since the first day he joined the free French naval forces, July 1st 1940 after he rallied England beginning June 19th.

In 1942, impressed by British methods and efficiency (don't get me started…) he created the first embryo of French commando with twenty volunteers, but we must wait until the end of 1943 for the final creation of the 1st BFMC (Battalion Fusiliers Marine Commando). June 6th 1944, commander Keiffer landed on the Normandy coast leading 176 "Fumaco" (Fusiliers Marine Commando), the only representatives of the Free France armed forces in Normandy. In addition of his medals and becoming a "Compagnon de la Liberation" (liberation companion) at the end of the war, he started to get involve in politics with some success. Promoted to the rank of "capitaine de frégate" (lieutenant-colonel), he died in 1962 at the age of 63 after being a consultant for the movie "The Longest Day". Since 2008, the 6th marine commando of the French navy is named after commando Kiefer. Similarly, two other commando units are named Hubert and Trépel in memory of two other 1st BFCM officers who died in battle.

Laurent



1ST BFMC

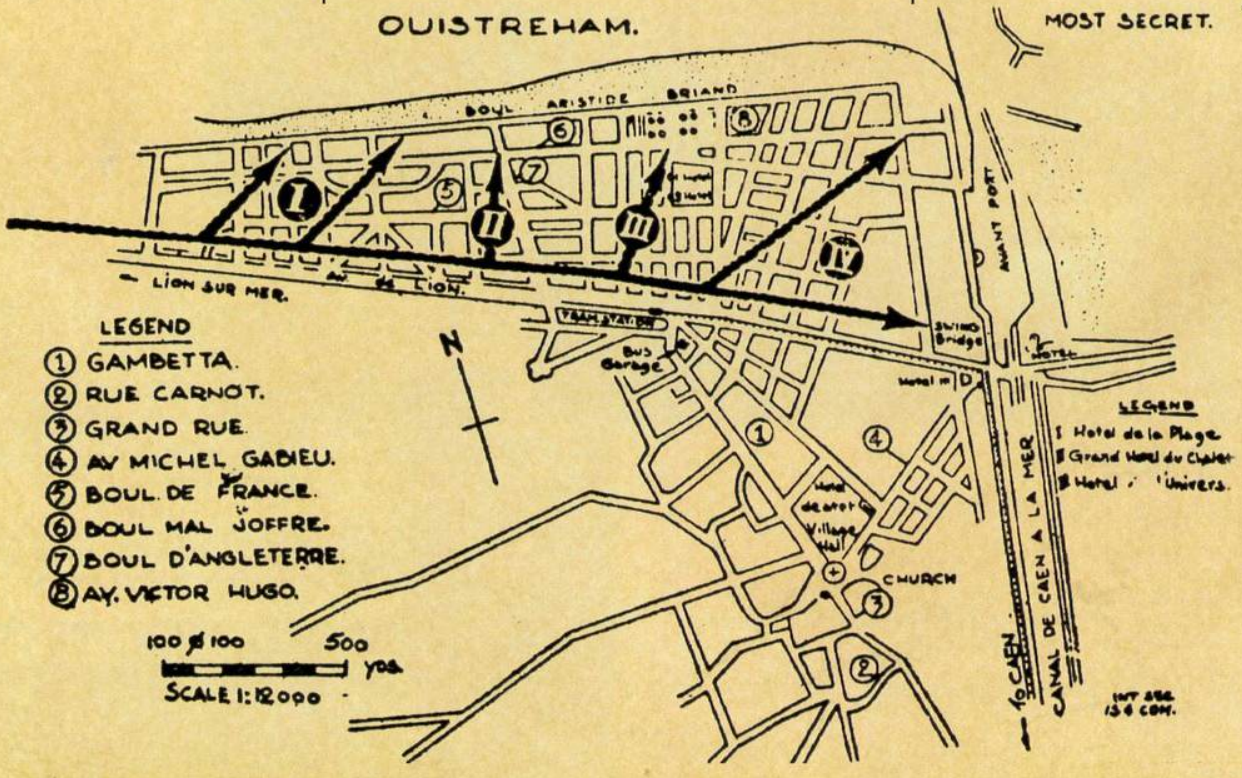
Created and organized like the British commando, the 1st BFMC owes its existence to the determination of Philippe Kieffer "enseigne de vaisseau" (lieutenant). Beginning in 1942, he brought together 25 sailers and some marines from the Basque area, intended to be an instruction unit only, to form the core group of the Battalion Fusiliers Marine Commando. From the beginning, Kieffer had in mind to have a real, 100% French combat unit integrated to the British commando operations. The training in Scotland is… really hard. The kind where you spit blood while rolling yourself in the cold mud, under the fire of real ammunition and the mean bark of a sadist British instructor who hates Frenchies (May he freeze his balls off!). Results are good despite being only 80 men strong, the small battalion sent 15 men to participate in the Dieppe raid in August 1942 (nice vacation on the beach…). The agenda is not too crazy since they have to wait for 1943 to begin before participating in a hand full of German defense reconnaissance raids from the coast of France to the ones of The Netherlands. Those "helping hands" are not successful, far from it, since the Germans are not always as cooperative as hoped. The commando will lose a dozen men.

Finally, in March '44, after the arrival of some reinforcements, the French marine commandos received the title of Battalion. It will be later linked to Lieutenant-Colonel Dawson's 4th Commando of Lord Lovat 1st Special Service Brigade himself!

For history, the 1st BFMC is especially known for their June 6th 1944 Normandy landing on Sword Beach, in the Queen red/green sector (between Hermanville and Colleville). 177 French were the first to rush onto the beaches in the assault of Ouistreham through Riva-Bella before reaching the bridge in Benouville where Lovat and Major Howard's paratroopers were waiting for them. The 1st BFMC was scheduled to fight only few days, but they stayed on zone until September 6th. Of the 177 first Free French who landed on D-Day, 17 were killed and, only 24 avoided injury.

As a unit, the 1st BFMC should have received the distinction of "Compagnons de la Libération" (which was the case for Kieffer personally). But General De Daulle decided otherwise: after all, the French men were under foreign command, weren't they? The survivors did receive the Legion d'Honneur, but not until 2004.
Anyway…

Laurent



Facsimile of the plan of the town of Ouistreham given to the fighters on 5 June 1944